

Week 19: Deity

BIG IDEA

Don't assume your students believe Jesus is God; many love his teaching with no intention of following him as God. In John 8 Jesus flatly claims deity, 'before Abraham was born, I am,' and there is evidence backing the claim. Press students with Jesus' own question: who do you say I am?

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- The speaker assumed for years his students believed Jesus is God, until conversations, including one with Mormon visitors at his door, showed otherwise.
- Students focus on John 8, where Jesus flatly says 'before Abraham was born, I am,' the claim that made the religious leaders want to kill him.
- The intro activity has students write who they think they are, whether others agree, and what evidence backs it, like a scorer being a basketball player.
- The trick: Jesus says who he is, and we have evidence for who he says he is; that combination gives us something solid.
- Expect students to accept Jesus as a great moral teacher but resist him as God, because accountability to the God of the universe carries unwanted implications.
- Like Jesus asking Peter in Matthew 16, ask students who they say Jesus is and why; if only a teacher, is it evidence or willingness?

SCRIPTURE

John 8 • Matthew 16

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Who do you say Jesus is, and why do you answer that way?
2. What evidence backs up who you think you are, and what evidence backs up who Jesus claims to be?
3. Why is it easier to accept Jesus as a good moral teacher than as God of the universe?
4. If you see Jesus as only a teacher, what would it take to see him as God: more evidence, or willingness?

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